Writing Assignment, Part 1: Proposal

ECON 201

Due Monday, November 16, before class, on Canvas. Worth 5% of your course grade.

In this assignment, you will be an **economic naturalist**.[1] A naturalist looks at the living world and asks why things are the way they are. You will do the same with everyday economic life. **Find a pattern of events or behavior you have observed, ask why it happens, and answer the question with an idea from this course.** The assignment has two parts:

- **Part 1: Proposal.** Due Monday, November 16, worth 5%. Describe what you observed, state your question, and give your first guess at the answer.
- **Part 2: Essay.** Due Monday, December 7, worth 10%. Answer your question with a course idea.

What Makes a Good Question

1. **It can be answered with a course idea.** Before you settle on a question, ask yourself which idea from this course could explain what you observed.
2. **It is a puzzle.** What you observed would surprise someone thinking about it casually, because it is not what they would expect.
3. **It is original.** Few other students are likely to pick it, and it is not a classic textbook puzzle or a question you can find on the internet. A question that comes from something you observed in your daily life is much more likely to be original.
4. **It is real.** It is something that actually happens and that you could point to, not a hypothetical.
5. **It is not a matter of opinion.** It asks why something happens, not whether it should.

Your Proposal

Write **one paragraph of no more than 150 words**, entered directly as text on Canvas, that covers the following, **in this order**:

1. What did you observe, where, and when, and why is it puzzling?
2. What is your question? State it in one sentence.
3. What is your first guess at the answer, and which course idea is behind it? All topics in the course count, even the ones we have not reached. Do not worry if you are not sure your answer is right; a good-faith attempt is what matters.

Grading Rubric

Proposal (5 points)	**Points**
The question can be answered with an idea from this course (a hypothetical or an opinion question earns 0 here)	2
The question is a puzzle, and the proposal makes clear what you observed, where and when, and why it is surprising	1
The question is original	1
The first guess names a course idea and is a good-faith attempt at the answer	1

[1] The assignment follows Robert Frank's economic naturalist assignment.